

Chapter 52_1: Head Pat

"Penglai." Chu Qing Qiu repeated her words, looking at her innocent face for a few more moments.

This Baili Shi Qi truly had no scheming thoughts at all, bringing up exactly what shouldn't be mentioned. Ning Fu Yi looked at Chu Qing Qiu's tense expression and quickly changed the subject, moving closer to examine the fierce ghost: "This ghost's resentment is truly thick. I wonder what she experienced in life to make her refuse to enter the underworld after death and instead condense into human form."

Hearing this, Chu Qing Qiu stopped dwelling on Baili Shi Qi's words and turned her attention back to the fierce ghost. She pointed her fingertip to her temple and drew out a thread of silk-like light.

The light penetrated the barrier and fell into the fierce ghost's forehead. The previously shrill screaming weakened somewhat, finally stopping weakly. The grotesque face and tattered clothes were covered by white light, and when the light dispersed, it returned to human appearance.

But it wasn't Qiu Lan's appearance—it was another woman, even more delicate than Qiu Lan. She had elegantly shaped eyebrows and cherry lips, wearing emerald-colored robes, kneeling there pitifully.

All three were somewhat surprised, because this woman's accessories and demeanor didn't seem like those of a mountain villager at all. She had a scholarly air about her, like a lady from a prestigious family.

With the resentful energy removed from the woman, she had now regained her sanity. She glared hatefully at Chu Qing Qiu and flew forward trying to attack her, only to be blocked by the barrier. Her black hair scattered on the ground as she wailed with tears.

"Just a little more, just a little more! Who are you? Why are you helping them bully me!"

"You evil ghost! You've harmed a hundred people and still won't stop. You're clearly the one killing innocents—why are you reversing right and wrong!" Shi Qi frowned.

"Bah! They deserved what they got. Everyone here should die!" The woman's eyes were bloodshot.

Seeing the woman's emotions were difficult to calm, Ning Fu Yi suddenly turned and ran back to the chaotic room, reaching out to hold the baby still lying on the bed. However, as soon as her hand touched the edge of the swaddling clothes, the baby inside stopped breathing.

Ning Fu Yi quickly picked up the baby and touched that pale little face, only to discover this was actually a corpse that had been dead for who knows how long. Her heart jumped in shock—she hadn't noticed anything wrong when she looked at the baby during the day, but now...

However, she quickly understood. During the day, she must have been deceived by corpse animation magic¹. Corpse animation was a type of puppet technique, but it was a famous forbidden art. This was because its method of activation was extremely harsh—it required making a puppet from a corpse that had died recently and hadn't yet rotted, so it could imitate the appearance and movements of a living person.

So she picked up the baby and ran back to the courtyard, placing down the swaddling clothes and saying to Chu Qing Qiu: "Corpse animation magic. This isn't her child."

Before Chu Qing Qiu could speak, the woman on the ground stopped wailing and spoke quietly: "That is my child."

"It's my child that I dug out from my own corpse," she said.

Ning Fu Yi immediately felt a chill. She glanced at Chu Qing Qiu, whose facial expression didn't change much, but the white bone² in her palm spun in a circle, with the jade flute's tip pointing at the terrified woman.

"Return," her vermillion lips parted slightly.

Immediately, a strange memory appeared in the minds of all three present.

It turned out this woman was named Cui Shu Lan. Her home was in Chuan An City³, a thousand li⁴ away from the village. Her father was the prefect of the city, a good official who had been honest all his life. Her mother was the daughter of a civil official from the capital, also a gentle and kind person.

Under the guidance of such parents, Cui Shu Lan was proficient in music, chess, calligraphy, and painting from a young age. Combined with her naturally beautiful appearance, she attracted countless young talents who thought of her day and night, with marriage proposals breaking down their door.

However, Cui Shu Lan was not an ordinary woman. She had no interest in those so-called talents, instead focusing her heart on reading. Although as a woman she couldn't take the imperial examinations, she loved writing essays, and her poems and writings were often circulated among literati.

Over time, she became a famous talented woman far and wide.

Fortunately, her parents were both reasonable people who didn't prevent her from studying. They even specially invited teachers from the capital to instruct her, and the family lived in great harmony.

Such a story should have become a good tale, but everything came to an abrupt halt on a rainy day.

That day, Cui Shu Lan was selecting books at a bookstore when suddenly the clear sky turned to torrential rain. The bookstore owner, fearing the rain would wet the books, closed early. She had to run home under her attendant's protection, but there were too many people seeking shelter on the road. After being jostled several times, she was separated from her attendant. Cui Shu Lan had to cover herself from the rain with her hands and return to the mansion alone.

However, halfway there, she saw a woman selling wild fruits by the roadside. The woman was soaked with rain, her cart's fruits scattered on the ground as she pitifully gathered them. Seeing this, Cui Shu Lan felt compassion and went forward to help.

But little did she know that this one act of help would send her into hell. She had just picked up two wild fruits when she felt severe pain in the back of her head and lost consciousness.

When she woke up again, she was tied up and thrown in a pitch-black room. She shouted and screamed in terror for a long time before finally summoning that woman, who smiled and placed a bowl of pig slop-like food beside her, touching her face: "What a pretty girl. In the future, you'll bear my Da Lang a fat son, and our family won't treat you badly."

Cui Shu Lan was both angry and terrified. She couldn't break free no matter how she struggled, and refused to eat that food even if it meant death. But she was severely beaten with a donkey whip by a man. The severe pain accompanied by abyss-like despair—to avoid being beaten to death, she had no choice but to comply with tears.

From then on, the talented woman Cui Shu Lan of Chuan An City became the wife of the Zhang family in Axe Head Village—Zhang-shi.

The days in Axe Head Village were very difficult. During the day she farmed and plowed, and at night she was abused. She had thought about escaping. But she was physically weak, surrounded by deep mountains and forests, and the entire village was united. As soon as she ran out of the village, she would be surrounded and blocked by hundreds of people. Every time she was dragged back to the village, she would receive another beating.

Over time, she lost even the thought of escaping, only living like a walking corpse. She gave birth to one child and miscarried a second. She felt no love for the child she bore, only disgust. No matter how much time passed, she could never forget that she had once been the spirited Cui Shu Lan of Chuan An City.

So the hatred and resentment accumulated over several years had nowhere to vent. Finally, on another rainy night, she used a grass-cutting sickle to pierce through her own stomach. Blood gushed out, and the pain made her already numb brain come alive again.

She finally felt the long-lost freedom and joy.

The light of memory gradually dimmed. The three stood frozen in place, and when their gazes fell on the woman again, their hearts were filled with mixed emotions.

She should have been heaven's favored daughter, a wild goose soaring in the sky. But just because she was a woman, just because of a moment of kindness, she was bound in this sunless mountain village and reduced to a tool for reproduction.

How tragic.

The world always demands good people to do good, pure people to be vigilant, and suffering people to be magnanimous, yet turns a blind eye to true evil. In front of Cui Shu Lan, Ning Fu Yi could no longer utter a single word of reproach.

If it were her, even burning down the entire village as burial companions would hardly be enough to vent her anger.

"What happened then?" Chu Qing Qiu spoke, her fingertips visibly white, as if suppressing anger.

"Then," Cui Shu Lan's eyes filled with hatred, "I thought I would be reincarnated, but unexpectedly became a wandering soul that wouldn't disperse. I don't know why I returned to the village, only to see my own corpse casually thrown in the pigsty!"

"I was nothing more than livestock they had tied up—they wouldn't even give me a dirt grave. Since they wouldn't let me rest in peace even in death, I would fulfill their wishes. I want all those who ruined my future, who humiliated me, who watched coldly or even added fuel to the fire—every single one of them to die horribly!"

"So you transformed into Qiu Lan, were tied up here again, created that nursery rhyme, and plunged this village into terror," Chu Qing Qiu said.

"Yes." Cui Shu Lan slowly stood up, arrogantly wiping the tears from her face. "Killing them all would be too easy. I want them to suffer day and night, to die in extreme terror."

"You originally wanted to save the Zhang family for last, but who knew you'd attract underworld judges⁵. So after killing the judge, you accelerated your actions, preparing to exterminate them all tonight."

Cui Shu Lan said nothing more, which was tantamount to agreement.

Everyone fell into silence. Ning Fu Yi felt as if a huge stone was stuck in her heart, difficult to resolve. She looked toward Chu Qing Qiu and saw her fingertip move slightly.

At the same time, the pigsty door creaked open. The woman who had been unconscious inside for a long time awakened in confusion, her hand touching the muddy ground as she struggled to stand. Only then did she remember her son's death, repeatedly shouting "Da Lang" as she rushed out, only to come face to face with Cui Shu Lan.

The woman immediately opened her mouth silently, her eyes bulging as if about to fly out. She kept making gasping sounds from her throat, but was too frightened to speak a word.

Finally, under the moonlight, her complexion gradually turned blue, then gray like a corpse. She fell down stiffly, her face twisted grotesquely.

Baili Shi Qi beside them quickly ran forward, placing her finger under the woman's nose, saying in terror: "She, she's stopped breathing!"

Who would have thought that this woman, after a lifetime of evil deeds, would be frightened to death by two scares in succession. Cui Shu Lan suddenly let out a piercing laugh, looking up at the crescent moon that had appeared at some point, appearing mad. As she laughed, tears began to fall.

The older child ran out from somewhere, crying loudly at Cui Shu Lan's face and calling for mother.

Cui Shu Lan looked at him, her gaze tender for a moment, then suddenly spread her arms, staggering as she reached for that bright moon, murmuring something softly.

"A woman pursuing literature is truly guilty, how can she bear to chant about moon and wind."⁶

"Wearing through iron inkstones is not my affair, breaking gold needles in embroidery is my achievement."

Bell sounds rang out along with her voice, as if echoing for her. The woman's pure white figure in the moonlight grew fainter and fainter, finally becoming silent flowing light that fell into the copper bell⁷ in Chu Qing Qiu's hand.

The barrier broke, the ghostly energy disappeared, weak stars twinkled at the horizon, and the deep blue sky was as clean as if washed with water.

Chu Qing Qiu's eyes filled with compassion as she put away the bell.

Footnotes:

1. **Corpse animation magic (尸活术):** A forbidden puppet technique that animates recently deceased bodies to make them appear alive
2. **White bone (白骨):** Chu Qing Qiu's signature weapon, a bone-white jade flute with divine properties
3. **Chuan An City (川安城):** A fictional city name meaning "River Peace City"
4. **Li (里):** Traditional Chinese unit of distance, approximately 500 meters
5. **Underworld judges (判官):** Officials in Chinese mythology who determine the fate of souls after death
6. **Classic Chinese poetry:** These lines reflect the traditional view that women should focus on domestic duties rather than literature
7. **Copper bell (铜铃铛):** A magical item used to contain and pacify souls or spirits